The outpouring of nationwide sympathy following Indira's death assured the Congress Party, led by Indira's son Rajiv, its strongest historic victory. Zia had flown to Delhi to meet with Rajiv at Indira Gandhi's funeral, and saw him there again in December 1985, after the first meeting of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) in Dhaka in Bangladesh, when they agreed not to attack each other's nuclear installations. That promising start to a hopeful process of South Asian reconciliation was followed, however, by a futile series of five rounds of talks on the deadly conflict over the Siachen Glacier, Kashmir's highest frozen peak, just east of the Line of Control.[3] Since 1984, when the Indian army first occupied these heights, thousands of Indian and Pakistani soldiers have died fighting over the glacier. Uncounted amounts of money have been wasted by both sides in exchanging heavy artillery fire over it.

Soon after Benazir was elected, she met with Rajiv for a two-day summit in Islamabad in June 1989. These youthful heirs to dynastic power, both of the same generation, appeared to like each other. Had they remained in high office longer, and lived long enough, they might well have reached diplomatic agreements on how best to stop fighting over frozen wastelands like Siachen, squandering their nations' most preciously valuable resources in Kashmir, and built instead "on the progress in Pakistan-Indian relations our parents had established in the Simla Accord," as Benazir Bhutto much later wisely noted.[4]

But Rajiv Gandhi failed to take swift advantage of the wave of popularity and sympathy that had lifted him to the peak of Indian power, and he soon lost his reputation as "Mr. Clean," allowing two very promising accords he had reached with popular leaders of Punjab and Assam to lapse for lack of initiative as well as energy. He tried to end the Sri Lankan civil war by sending an Indian peacekeeping force to Jaffna, but that mission also failed. Then, on the eve of what might well have been his Congress Party's reelection to power in 1991, Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated by a Tamil Tiger terrorist woman while campaigning near Madras.

Benazir lost the confidence of Pakistan's leaders of the all-powerful ISI, Generals Hamid Gul and Durrani, who viewed her as "too soft" toward India, realizing that like her father she was ready to accept the Line of Control as the international border. The ISI invested heavily in undermining her PPP's majority, until new elections were called less than two years after Benazir had taken power, and in October 1990 her